

Why Do I Keep Starting Over? — Workbook

A Companion Guide to the Rotten Fencepost Principle

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This workbook is provided as a companion resource to the Rotten Fencepost teaching and may be used for personal reflection and study.

Introduction

Have you ever found yourself saying these words? "This time will be different." Maybe it was about your health, your finances, your relationship, or your walk with the Lord. You made a decision, you had every intention to follow through — for a little while, you did — and then one day you woke up and realized you were right back where you started.

If that has ever happened to you, this workbook exists to suggest something: the problem probably isn't that you don't care, that you're lazy, or that you lack discipline. Maybe, just maybe, you're fixing the wrong thing.

This workbook will not tell you what your "wrong thing" is. Only you can find that — it's specific to your life. What it will give you is a method: the same method taught in the video, broken into honest questions and small, doable exercises.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this workbook, you will be able to:

- Describe, in your own words, the difference between fixing a symptom and fixing a cause.
- Identify one pattern of "starting over" in your own life.
- Ask a different, better question than "why can't I stay consistent?"
- Practice beginning with curiosity instead of guilt or shame.
- Write one concrete first step toward finding the actual cause, not just the wire.

Teaching Summary — What Is This Fence Attached To?

For many years, Kahu Phil has been blessed to live and work as a paniolo in Hawaii. One lesson the land teaches over and over is this: a fence doesn't usually fail all at once. You might first notice a loose wire, then a leaning section, then an animal gets through. Most people look at the wire — because that's what they can see. But an experienced paniolo learns to ask another question: what is this fence attached to? Because if the post underneath has begun rotting, it doesn't matter how tight you pull that wire. Sooner or later, the fence is coming down.

People are not much different. We spend so much of our lives repairing the wire in our lives — we buy another planner, start another diet, make another budget, promise ourselves that tomorrow will be different. There's nothing wrong with those things. The problem comes when we expect them to fix something they were never designed to fix. If the fence post is rotten, new wire is not the answer.

Symptoms are often loud. Causes are usually quiet. Symptoms demand attention today; causes patiently wait on the ground. That is true in relationships, in finances, in health, and in our spiritual lives. If all we ever do is respond to what we can see, we may spend our entire lives repairing the same fence.

The Question That Changes Everything

Instead of asking "why can't I stay consistent?", what if we ask "what keeps bringing me back here?" That's a very different question — and sometimes, just sometimes, it's the beginning of freedom.

1. Think of something you've had to "start over" on more than once. What was it?
2. When you've asked yourself why before, what question did you usually ask? (Be honest — was it closer to "why can't I stay consistent" or something else self-blaming?)
3. Try asking the different question instead: what keeps bringing you back here? Write down whatever comes, even if it isn't a full answer yet.
4. Don't begin with guilt. Don't begin with shame. Begin with curiosity. What happened right before you quit, or became discouraged, or made the decision that started the cycle again?

Practical Exercise — What Is Feeding This?

Write down the pattern in one sentence (the thing you keep starting over on).

Now ask: "what is feeding this?" — not the surface trigger, but what keeps the pattern alive underneath. Write down everything that comes to mind, even things that feel unrelated at first.

Look at what you wrote. Is there one fence post underneath all of it — one real cause that, if addressed, would matter more than any new planner, diet, or budget?

Find the Cause Worksheet

The thing I keep starting over on: _____

The "new wire" I've tried before (planner, diet, budget, promise, etc.):

How long it lasted before I was back where I started:

What keeps bringing me back here (not why can't I stay consistent, but what's feeding this):

The fence post I believe is actually rotting: _____

One action this week that begins with curiosity, not guilt:

Reflection Pages

Use this space to write freely in response to the question: What happened before I quit, before I became discouraged, before I made that decision — and what is feeding this?

Action Plan

This Week: _____

This Month: _____

Ongoing: _____

Closing — Find the Cause, Fix the Cause

The subjects change, but the principles do not. Whether we're talking about families, health, money, leadership, or faith, the principle remains the same: if you find the cause, if you fix the cause, you can change the future.

For the video this workbook was built alongside, and the rest of the Rotten Fencepost teaching series, visit <https://keaupuniakeakua.faith/rotten-fencepost>.